Opening Access to Indigenous Data in Australia

IASSIST 2007

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The Australian Social Science Data Archive

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Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islanders are warned that the following presentation may contain images of deceased persons

Outline

- Introduction to ASSDA
- Background to Indigenous research
- Indigenous data as a closed system
- Building trust to open data
- The IDA Model
- Conclusions

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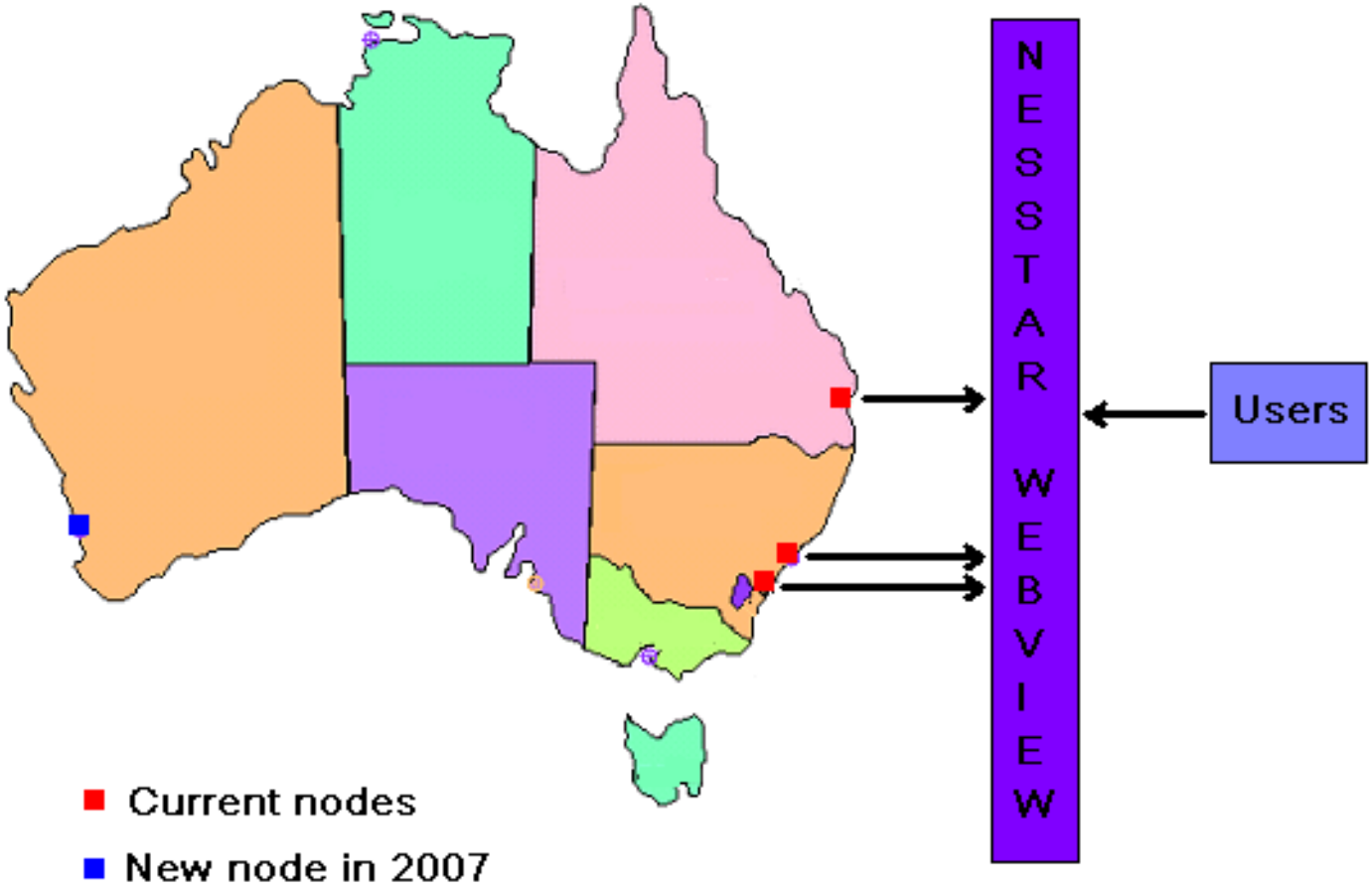
The ASSDA Distributed Model



Specialisation in the Distributed Model Opens Data

- Creates a space to investigate and solve access problems associated with particular data types
- Can be located in a research group where there is expertise to solve the problems with the data type
- Exists within its user community and so supports continued funding and therefore sustainability

Data Types in IDA

Qualitative

Quantitative

Other
eg. Statistical Publications

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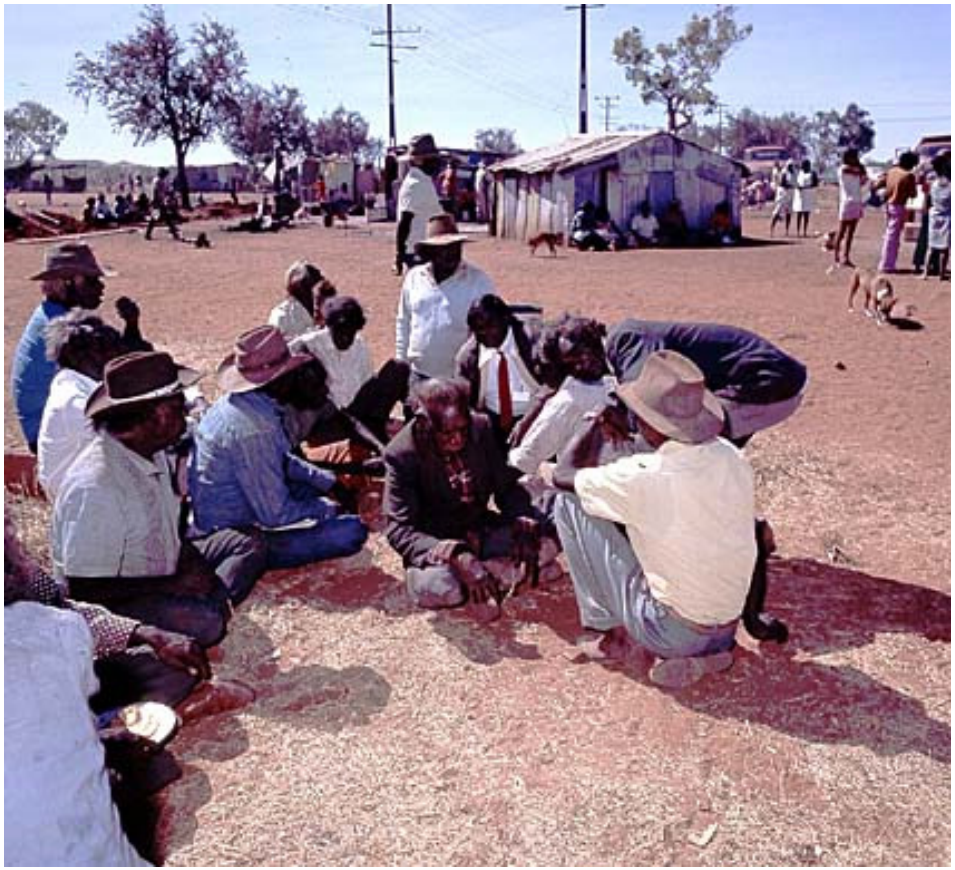
Indigenous Data as a Closed System

Indigenous data is currently closed because

- Data and metadata (if it exists!) are hidden
- Nothing goes outside the research group

The system is closed to protect this small, readily identifiable population and due to past abuse



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About the Indigenous Population

- At the 2001 Census, the Indigenous population was 458 520 (2.4%) of the Australian population (19.3 million)
- A history of mistreatment of Indigenous population
- Aboriginal people with greater that 50% Indigenous blood not counted in official statistics until ‘71 Census
- Increased cultural and political awareness and acknowledgement of Indigenous origins following govt. initiatives such as the creation of ATSIC in 1990, Stolen Generation Inquiry, Declaration of Land Rights, Native Title Act, Deaths in Custody Inquiry

The Hindmarsh Island Affair

- Developers building a marina wanted to build bridge to an island. Ngarrandjeri women claimed island was sacred for reasons that couldn't be revealed
- As part of process Ngarrandjeri women wrote down secrets marked "Confidential to be read by Women Only"
- A male politician tabled the secret documents in Parliament

A deliberate breech of Indigenous customs and values caused trouble in Indigenous community

The Diane Bell Affair

- Diane Bell with Topsy Napurrula Nelson (a Pawurrinji woman) published an academic article about intra-racial rape in the Aboriginal community
- Huge furore as it was felt by the Aboriginal community that it was a white persons perceptions of an Aboriginal community issue and claimed to be speaking on behalf of ALL Aboriginal women.
- She did not respect the diversity of Aboriginal communities

Other Research

- Good research is being done around the country by organisations which work closely with the Indigenous communities

Separate research groups that by and large don't share their data – even with each other

- Centre for Aboriginal Economic Policy Research, AIATSIS, ABS, AIHW
- Universities eg Edith Cowan, Newcastle, Adelaide, Charles Darwin

The research is good because it respects Indigenous rights, culture and diversity

AIATSIS Guidelines for Ethical Research in Indigenous Studies

A. Consultation, negotiation and mutual understanding

- Important to look at informed consent
- The community should be consulted at every step of the life cycle so there is a mutual understanding about proposed research

B. Respect, recognition and involvement

- Indigenous knowledge, culture must be respected
- Diversity between Indigenous groups need to be recognised
- IP and Cultural property must be preserved
- Involve Indigenous researchers as partners

C. Benefits, outcomes and agreements

- Use of and access to research results need to be agreed with communities
- Researched community must benefit from the research

Other Research

- The ethical guidelines serve to protect the Indigenous population from exploitation

- But it also closes the data and acts as a disincentive to preservation and sharing

Opening Indigenous Data While Respecting Guidelines

<u>The primary goal is to establish trust</u>

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- The Indigenous population consider themselves to be the most surveyed group in the world – repurposing of data is critical
- ASSDA is using guidelines provided by the Trusted Digital Repository Framework to help community buy-in

See www.rlg.org for info on TDR

A. The Organisation

- A clear mission statement
- Highly skilled staff
- Strong rights managements policy and procedures
- Offer an Indigenous student internship to do processing
- Regularly review and update policies and procedures
- Financial sustainability not great – but have more chance surrounded by research group

B. Repository Functions, Processes & Procedures

- IDA will use ASSDA's practices developed for quantitative data
- Developments made at AQuA will guide qualitative data deposits
- HCCDA preservation techniques will be used to manage documents and statistical publications

C. Designated Community and Usability of Information

- Information will need to be usable by Indigenous Researchers, and provide assistance to Indigenous people want to access data but have no resources to use it
- Employing an Indigenous staff member ensures each record dealt with in a culturally sensitive manner
- Having a board of Indigenous Researchers to direct access policies, create disclaimers for inappropriate studies

D. Technologies and Technical Infrastructure

- Time tested technology and infrastructure developed across other ASSDA nodes will be used

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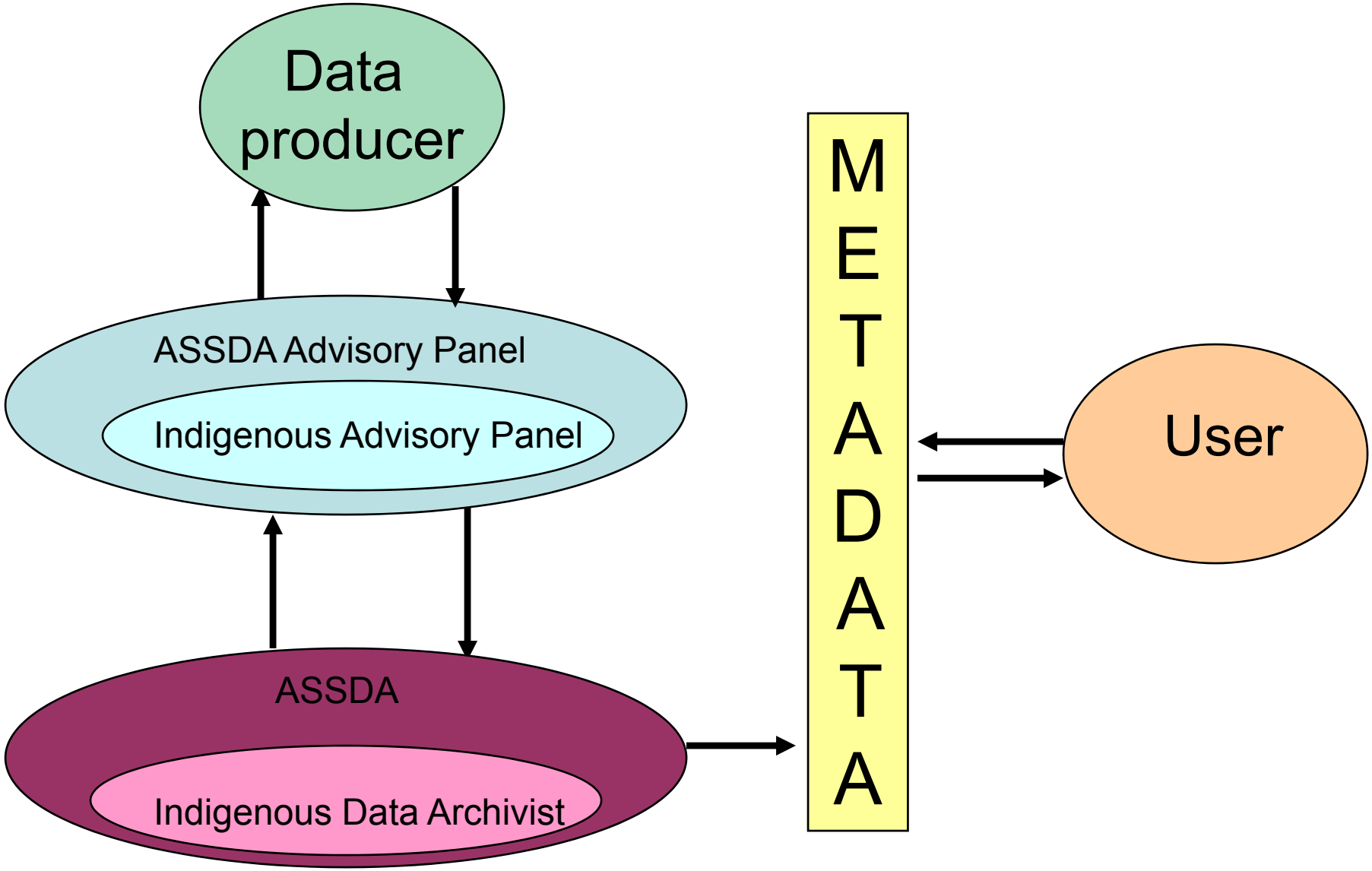
Proposed structure of IDA



Conclusion

We are hoping by getting the Indigenous population involved in the project by establishing trust we can

- open data while still respecting the rights of our Indigenous people
- providing access to research data that could drive research beneficial to the Indigenous communities and Australia at large

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